

Snipe Hunt JavaFX Edition - User Guide

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The master version of this document can be viewed at:

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1fTrR5vQknKrvPBtWhrVsf_ePw8wuyItaq6RTW-e76SI/edit?usp=sharing.

If you are viewing this document from the JavaFX application, I recommend you open the master, as the master is more nicely formatted.

Table of Contents

- Unofficial Rulebook
 - Conventions
 - Overview
 - (?) Cards Used
 - (?) Setup
 - Taking a Turn
 - Taking an Animal Step
 - Activating a Triplet
 - Taking a Snipe Step
 - Making a Drop
 - (?) Card Elements
- Glossary
- Controls
 - Performing Actions
 - How to Read the Action History

Unofficial Rulebook

Conventions

- You may notice some words are italicized, like *this*. Pay attention to these words, as they are key terms.
- The rulebook is organized into sections (“Conventions”, “Overview”, “(?) Cards Used”, etc.).
- Some sections have titles prefixed with “(?)”.

- When playing the JavaFX implementation, the computer takes care of the rules defined in these sections, so you don't have to worry about them.
- Consequently, reading these sections is optional (but recommended).
- However, if you want to play with physical cards, reading them is mandatory.

Overview

- The game is played between two players: alpha and beta.
- Each player has one snipe. The objective of the game is to *capture* the opponent's snipe.
 - Alternatively, you can also win by leaving your opponent with zero legal *actions*.
- The game is played by taking turns until one of the players has won.

(?) Cards Used

- 1 alpha snipe
- 1 beta snipe
- 32 *animals*. An animal is any card that is not a snipe. Animals:
 - 8 major animals (2 tigers, 2 dragons, 2 fish, 2 elephants).
 - 24 minor animals (2 rats, 2 oxen, 2 rabbits, 2 snakes, 2 horses, 2 rams, 2 monkeys, 2 roosters, 2 dogs, 2 boars).
- The following cards are *retreaters* (cards that are allowed to move backwards): alpha snipe, beta snipe, rat, rabbit, snake, ram, boar, squid.

(?) Setup

- Shuffle the 24 minor animals. Deal 12 into each player's *deck*, face-down.
- Shuffle the 8 major animals. Deal 4 into each player deck, face-down.
- Shuffle each player's deck.
- Deal the cards face-up into 8 rows, as specified below:
 - Alpha reserve: 1 card from alpha's deck.
 - Rank 1: 2 cards from alpha's deck plus the alpha snipe, all *allegiant* to alpha
 - Rank 2: 12 cards from alpha's deck
 - Rank 3: 1 card from alpha's deck
 - Rank 4: 1 card from beta's deck
 - Rank 5: 12 cards from beta's deck

- Rank 6: 2 cards from beta's deck plus the beta snipe
- Beta reserve: 1 card from beta's deck.
- Every card is *allegiant* to either alpha or beta.
 - The cards in the alpha reserve, rank 1, rank 2, and rank 3 are allegiant to alpha.
 - The cards in rank 4, rank 5, rank 6, and the beta reserve are allegiant to beta.
 - If playing with physical cards, you can denote the allegiance of each card with its orientation:
 - Players sit at opposite ends of a table.
 - Cards allegiant to alpha face away from alpha (i.e., such that the text on the cars appears upside-down to beta).
 - Cards allegiant to beta face away from beta (i.e., such that the text on the cars appears upside-down to alpha).
- Note that the middle 6 rows are *ranks* and the 2 rows on the end are *reserves*. This will be important later.

Taking a Turn

- Beta goes first.
- The player whose turn it is is called the *active player*.
- The other player is called the *inactive player*.
- Each turn, the active player has three choices. Each choice entails either taking one or two actions. Choices:
 - 1. Make two *animal step* actions.
 - An animal step action can be referred to simply as an "animal step" for short (i.e., the "action" can be omitted).
 - The steps must be made with two different cards.
 - However, the two cards can be the same animal (e.g., moving one rabbit and then moving the other rabbit is legal).
 - If you choose this option, you **must** take two animal steps. It is illegal to just take one animal step.
 - If you take one animal step and are unable to take a second animal step, you lose.
 - However, if you capture the enemy snipe with the first animal step, you immediately win the game. As the game has ended, you do not have to (and cannot) take another animal step.
 - 2. Make one *snipe step* action.

- A snipe step action can be referred to simply as a “snipe step” for short (i.e., the “action” can be omitted).
 - 3. Make one *drop* action.
 - A drop action can be referred to simply as a “drop” for short (i.e., the “action” can be omitted).
- If the active player cannot legally perform any of the above, they lose.

Taking an Animal Step

- The active player selects an animal that is allegiant to them.
 - The animal must be on a rank; it cannot be in the reserve.
- They can move it *forward*, or, if the card is a retreat, they can move it either forward or *backward*.
 - Moving forward means moving away from your reserve.
 - For alpha, this means increasing rank number (e.g., moving forward from rank 3 leads to rank 4).
 - For beta, this means decreasing rank number (e.g., moving forward from rank 3 leads to rank 2).
 - Moving backwards means moving toward your reserve.
 - For alpha, this means decreasing rank number (e.g., moving backward from rank 3 leads to rank 2).
 - For beta, this means increasing rank number (e.g., moving backward from rank 3 leads to rank 4).
- The new location of the card is called the *destination*.
- If the card *activates a triplet* by stepping onto the destination, all other cards on that destination are *captured*.
 - This means they become allegiant to the active player, and move into the active player’s reserve.
 - The card that moved is not captured. It should now be the only card on the destination.
- Restrictions:
 - You cannot *empty* a rank (leave a rank with zero cards) unless doing so immediately captures the enemy snipe.
 - You cannot step into a reserve. In other words, the destination must be a rank, not a reserve.
 - You cannot capture your own snipe unless doing so immediately captures the enemy snipe.

- As previously mentioned, if you already made an animal step this turn, you cannot move the same animal as the one you moved in the previous animal step.

Activating a Triplet

- There are four *elements*: fire, water, earth, and air.
- Every animal has three of those elements (e.g., “fire fire water”, “earth earth fire”, “air air air”).
 - The elements of each card are defined in the “Card Elements” section.
 - The *element count* of a card for a given element **E** is how many **E** that card has. For example:
 - The element count of a card that has “fire fire water” for the element fire is 2.
 - The element count of a card that has “fire fire water” for the element water is 1.
 - The element count of a card that has “fire fire water” for the element air is zero.
- For a given set of destination cards **D** and a card **C** that has just stepped onto **D**, **C** is said to *activate a triplet* by entering **D** if and only if for some element **E**, conditions (i), (ii), (iii), and (iv) are all true:
 - Let **U** be the set produced by adding the card **C** to the set **D**.
 - (i) **U** contains at least one card that has an element count of 1 for element **E**
 - (ii) **U** contains at least one card that has an element count of 2 for element **E**
 - (iii) **U** contains at least one card that has an element count of 3 for element **E**
 - (iv) The element count of **C** for element **E** is greater than zero.

Taking a Snipe Step

- The active player either moves their snipe forward or backward.
- Restrictions:
 - You cannot empty a rank by moving your snipe.

Making a Drop

- The active player selects an animal in their reserve.

- They move that animal onto any rank they choose.
- Restrictions:
 - You cannot *empty the reserve* (leave the reserve with zero cards).
 - You cannot drop a retreator onto your opponent's *back two ranks*.
 - Alpha's back two ranks are rank 1 and rank 2.
 - Beta's back two ranks are rank 5 and rank 6.

(?) Card Elements

- Alpha snipe: none
- Beta snipe: none
- Rat: fire, fire, earth
- Ox: earth, earth, water
- Tiger: fire, fire, fire
- Rabbit: air, air, water
- Dragon: air, air, air
- Snake: water, water, earth
- Horse: fire, fire, air
- Ram: earth, earth, air
- Monkey: air, air, earth
- Rooster: air, air, fire
- Dog: fire, fire, water
- Boar: earth, earth, fire
- Fish: water, water, water
- Elephant: earth, earth, earth
- Squid: water, water, fire
- Frog: water, water, air

Glossary

The glossary is just a brief recap on key terms. More detail can be found in the "Unofficial Rulebook" section. The terms are sorted alphabetically.

- Action: an animal step, snipe step, or drop.
- Activating a triplet: moving onto a rank such that that rank has cards with element counts of 1, 2, and 3 for some element. If the card has an element count of zero for that element, a triplet has not been activated. Triplets can only be activated through animal steps, not drops.
- Active player: the player whose turn it is to move.

- Allegiant: a card is allegiant to a player if that player “controls” or “owns” that card.
- Animal: a card that is not a snipe.
- Animal step: Moving an animal from one rank to another.
- Capture: remove from the destination rank and move into your reserve.
- Deck: each player’s stack of cards that they form by combining the minor and major cards dealt to them.
- Destination: the rank a card moves onto.
- Drop: taking a card from your reserve and moving it to a rank.
- Element count: how much of a given element a card has.
- Empty a rank/reserve: leave a row with zero cards in it after you move a card out of it. An action that does this is illegal unless it captures the enemy snipe.
- Inactive player: the active player’s opponent.
- Major animal: an animal with an element count of 3 for some element.
- Minor animal: an animal that does not have an element count of 3 for any element.
- Rank: one of the middle 6 rows. Cards can move from one rank to another, but they cannot enter a reserve except by being captured.
- Reserve: the first or last row. Each player’s reserve stores the cards they captured.
- Retreater: a card that can move backward as well as forward.
- Snipe step: moving a snipe from one rank to another.

Controls

Performing Actions

- In two-player mode, the user (you) controls both players. You can either play against yourself or find someone else to sit beside you to play.
- To perform an animal step:
 - Click on the card you want to move.
 - After you click it, it should be highlighted in green. If it is not, it means that either the card does not belong to the active player or the game is over.
 - Click on the rank you want to move it to.
- To perform a snipe step:
 - Click on the active player’s snipe.

- After you click it, it should be highlighted in green. If it is not, it means that either you clicked on the inactive player's snipe or the game is over.
 - Click on the rank you want to move it to.
- To perform a drop:
 - Click on the card (in the active player's reserve) you want to drop.
 - After you click it, it should be highlighted in green. If it is not, it means that either you clicked on a card in the inactive player's reserve or the game is over.
 - Click on the rank you want to drop it on.
- To undo an action:
 - Click on the "Undo" button at the bottom of the screen.
 - A full list of action history can be found to the right of that button.

How to Read the Action History

- Each turn is written "{turn number}{active player}. {actions};"
- By convention, the turn number starts at 3 (instead of 1). This is because 1 and 2 are traditionally used to record the way the cards were dealt.
 - If a turn consists of two animal steps, "{actions}" is replaced by "{first animal moved} -> {first destination}, {second animal moved} -> {second destination}"
 - If the most recent turn is pending (i.e., only one of the two animal steps has been performed), the "{actions}" is replaced by "{first animal moved} -> {first destination}..." (note the "..." to signal that the turn is incomplete)
 - If a turn consists of a snipe step, "{actions}" is replaced by "{active player} -> {destination}"
 - If a turn consists of a drop, "{actions}" is replaced by "![animal dropped] -> {destination}" (note the "!" to distinguish it from an animal step).
- At the end of the list of turns, the active player will be displayed (e.g., "Alpha to play"), or the winner if the game has ended (e.g. "Alpha is victorious").